

Academic Debate for Medical Students

What it is, why it matters, and how to do it effectively.



Assit. Professor Dr. Sherwan R Shal

sherwan.rahman@hmu.edu.krd

AY (2025-2026)

What Is an Academic Debate?



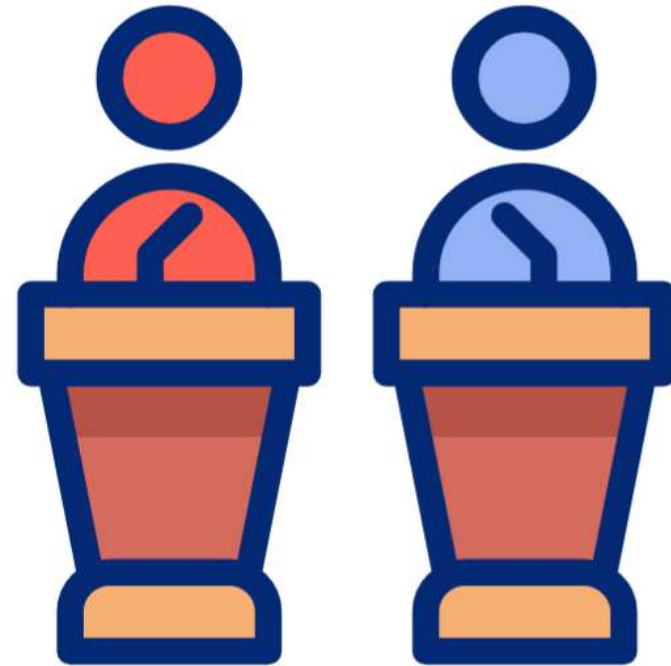
- An academic debate is:
a **structured, organized** discussion where two sides argue **for** or **against** a specific topic.
- It follows **rules**, uses **evidence**, and aims to build **critical thinking**—not to “win a fight.”

Why Is Debate Important in Medicine?

- Improves critical thinking
- Builds scientific reasoning
- Enhances communication and presentation skills
- Teaches students to evaluate evidence
- Encourages **respectful disagreement**

Structure of a Medical Debate

1. Motion/Topic
2. Proposition team (For)
3. Opposition team (Against)
4. Opening statements
5. Evidence-based arguments
6. Rebuttals
7. Closing statements
8. Judge's evaluation



What Is a Motion?



A motion = the debate topic written as a clear statement.

Examples:

- “Antibiotic stewardship should be mandatory in all hospitals.”
- “Artificial intelligence will replace 50% of medical jobs.”



The Proposition Team (For)

Role: Support the motion

They must:

- Provide scientific evidence
- Define key terms
- Explain why the topic is beneficial

Example: Arguing that “Vaccination should be compulsory.”

The Opposition Team (Against)

Role: Challenge the motion

They must:

- Present counter-evidence
- Expose weaknesses in the other side
- Protect alternative viewpoints

Example: Arguing that “Compulsory vaccination violates autonomy.”

Evidence in Medical Debates

Students should use:

- Peer-reviewed articles
- Meta-analyses
- Clinical guidelines
- WHO/CDC/NIH statements
- Local health statistics

Avoid:

- Anecdotes
- Social media claims
- Unsupported opinions

Types of Arguments

- 1. Logical arguments** (systematic reasoning)
- 2. Statistical arguments** (data-based)
- 3. Ethical arguments** (autonomy, justice, beneficence)
- 4. Clinical arguments** (outcomes, risks, benefits)

Logical Structure: Claim → Evidence → Explanation

Example:

- **Claim:** “Smoking increases risk of MI.”
- **Evidence:** (AHA 2024) Risk increases 2–4× in active smokers.
- **Explanation:** Nicotine causes vasoconstriction and endothelial injury.

What Is a Rebuttal?

- A rebuttal is *a response that directly challenges the opponent's argument using facts.*
- **Example:**
Opponent: "E-cigarettes are safe."
Rebuttal: "WHO reports increased risk of airway inflammation and nicotine addiction."

Debate Etiquette

Medical debates must follow professionalism:

- No interrupting
- No personal attacks
- Respect timing
- Use academic language
- Acknowledge limitations

Role of the Moderator

The moderator:

- Introduces the topic
- Manages time
- Controls fairness
- Keeps discipline
- Ensures both sides follow rules

Example Debate Topics in Medicine

- Should AI be allowed to diagnose patients without human supervision?
- Should medical students be required to take mental health screening yearly?
- Is fasting during Ramadan safe for all chronic disease patients?
- Should private healthcare be regulated by the government?
- Is daily vitamin D supplementation necessary for all adults?

Preparing for a Debate

1. Read the topic well
2. Assign roles
3. Collect evidence
4. Prepare arguments + counterarguments
5. Practice delivery
6. Anticipate opponent's claims

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